Who Stopped Answering? Pakistani Women and Pew's Trends on Extremist Groups, 2009–2014*

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Abstract

Between Pew's 2009 and 2014 surveys of Pakistan, the share of Pakistanis viewing the Taliban unfavorably fell from 70% to 59%, while the favorable share barely moved. Pew described extremist groups as "seen negatively, but less so in recent years," and press coverage read the third of respondents without an answer as reluctance to talk about the Taliban. The respondent-level data show something else. Among men, views of the Taliban did not change, and men answered the question as often in 2014 as in 2009. Among women, the share giving no answer rose from 25% to 53%, and it rose by similar amounts for the United States, China, and Iran. Women's answers about domestic politicians did not change. The rise is not explained by the larger share of women without schooling in the 2014 sample, and among the 23 countries Pew surveyed in both years, only Pakistan shows a rise confined to women. The reported softening toward the Taliban reflects a change in who answered, not a measured change in opinion.

1 Introduction

Pew's surveys are the most cited source on how Pakistanis view militant groups. Between 2009 and 2014, the share of respondents with an unfavorable view of the Taliban fell by 11 points, while the share with a favorable view stayed near one in ten. The difference went to respondents who gave no answer. This note shows that the rise in no answers came almost entirely from women and was not specific to militant groups. Pakistani women in 2014 were about as likely to decline to rate the United States as to decline to rate the Taliban. Men's no-answer shares moved by a few points at most, apart from two Middle Eastern groups few Pakistanis know, and men's views of the Taliban did not change.

The finding matters for two readings of the 2014 data. Pew reported that extremist groups were viewed less negatively than in earlier years, and that views of the Taliban had not changed substantially. Press coverage treated the third of respondents without an answer as a sign of reluctance to talk about the Taliban. Neither reading separates a change in opinion from a change in who answers.

*`https://github.com/finite-sample/pew-pakistan-nonresponse`.

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2 What Was Reported

Pew's July 2014 report on extremism states that "only 8% have a favorable view of this extremist organization, with a third of Pakistanis not offering an opinion," and that "views of the Taliban have not changed substantially in recent years" (Pew Research Center, 2014a). Its August 2014 report on Pakistan carries a chart titled "Extremists Seen Negatively, but Less So in Recent Years" (Pew Research Center, 2014b). Neither report discusses non-response by sex or flags a change in non-response over time. The August report notes one rise in non-response, for Imran Khan: "Roughly one-in-five (22%) offer no opinion about Khan, up from 11% two years ago."

Dawn covered the July report under the headline "Most Pakistanis fear extremism, dislike Taliban: survey" (Iqbal, 2014). It reported that "almost 60pc of the population in Pakistan sees the Taliban unfavourably. Only 8pc have a favourable view of this extremist organisation," and described the remainder as "a third of Pakistanis" who "are reluctant to offer an opinion."

3 Data

I use Pew's respondent-level files for the Spring 2009 and Spring 2014 Global Attitudes surveys (Pew Research Center, 2009, 2014c). Both Pakistan samples were interviewed face to face, using multi-stage area probability designs stratified by province and urbanity, with 1,254 respondents in 2009 and 1,203 in 2014. Both oversampled cities and are weighted to the national urban share. Coverage fell from about 90% of adults in 2009 to about 82% in 2014, as more insecure areas of Khyber Pakhtunkhwa and Balochistan were excluded along with the tribal areas, Gilgit-Baltistan, and Azad Kashmir. The 2014 survey was conducted under the direction of Princeton Survey Research Associates International; the 2009 documentation available to me does not name the fieldwork firm.

Each answer is coded as positive (very or somewhat favorable; often or sometimes justified; a very or somewhat serious threat), negative, or no answer (don't know or refused). All shares use Pew's weights. Standard errors use the Kish effective sample size, inflated by the design effect implied by Pew's stated margin of error for Pakistan in each year. The weighted estimates match Pew's published 2014 figures to within a point: 8% favorable and 59% unfavorable toward the Taliban, 11% favorable toward al Qaeda, and 3% saying suicide bombing is often or sometimes justified.

4 Women Stopped Answering

Table 1 reports the share giving no answer, by sex, for every item asked in Pakistan in both years. For the Taliban, the share rose from 25% to 53% among women and went from 15% to 14% among men. The same pattern holds for countries: women's no-answer share on the United States rose from 26% to 48%, while men's stayed at 7–8%. Questions about domestic politicians are the exception. Almost every woman rated Nawaz Sharif in both years (5% and 7% without an answer). The change is a general withdrawal by women from questions about foreign actors and militant groups, not a reluctance specific to the Taliban.

Hamas and Hezbollah are the one place men moved too: their no-answer shares rose among men by about as much as among women. These two groups were already unfamiliar in 2009, when about half of men and three-quarters of women gave no answer about them.

Table 1: Share giving no answer, Pakistan, by sex

	Women 2009	2014	Change (SE)	Men 2009	2014	Change (SE)
Taliban	25	53	+28 (4)	15	14	−1 (3)
al Qaeda	41	69	+28 (4)	20	25	+5 (3)
Hamas	76	92	+16 (3)	48	67	+20 (4)
Hezbollah	72	93	+20 (3)	49	69	+20 (4)
United States	26	48	+22 (4)	7	8	+1 (2)
China	23	37	+14 (4)	4	3	−1 (1)
Iran	34	50	+16 (4)	3	9	+6 (2)
Nawaz Sharif	5	7	+2 (2)	2	1	−1 (1)
Asif Ali Zardari	6	7	+1 (2)	1	1	+0 (1)
Suicide bombing justified	6	13	+7 (3)	4	8	+4 (2)
Taliban a threat	20	47	+27 (4)	7	13	+6 (3)

Weighted percentages of respondents answering don't know or refusing. Changes are in percentage points, with standard errors in parentheses that use the design effect implied by Pew's stated margin of error.

5 The Reported Trend Is This Shift

Table 2 splits the headline Taliban numbers by sex. Men's views did not move: 74% unfavorable in 2009 and 75% in 2014. Women's unfavorable share fell from 66% to 42%, and nearly all of that went to no answer, not to a favorable view. The 11-point fall in unfavorable views of the Taliban in the full sample is women leaving the question unanswered.

Al Qaeda is different. Men's views did soften: their favorable share rose from 8% to 15% and their unfavorable share fell from 72% to 60%. For al Qaeda, Pew's "less so in recent years" describes something real among men, on top of the same withdrawal by women.

6 Not a Change in Who Was Sampled

The 2014 sample contains more women without formal schooling: 49% of women in 2009 and 61% in 2014. Respondents without schooling give no answer more often, so the shift could account for part of the rise. It accounts for little of it (Table 3). Women's no-answer share on the Taliban rose within both groups, from 37% to 62% among women without schooling and from 13% to 40% among women with some. Holding 2014 at the 2009 education mix gives 51%, against 53% observed.

The smaller coverage in 2014 cannot explain a change confined to women either, since excluding insecure districts removes men and women alike.

Table 2: Favorable, unfavorable, and no answer, Pakistan, by sex

	Fav. 2009	Unfav.	No answer	Fav. 2014	Unfav.	No answer
Taliban	10	70	20	8	59	33
Women	9	66	25	5	42	53
Men	11	74	15	11	75	14
al Qaeda	9	61	30	11	42	46
Women	11	49	41	7	23	69
Men	8	72	20	15	60	25
United States	16	68	16	14	59	27
Women	16	57	26	16	37	48
Men	15	78	7	12	80	8

Weighted percentages. Rows may not sum to 100 because of rounding.

Table 3: No answer by schooling, Pakistan

	None 2009	None 2014	Some 2009	Some 2014	All 2009	All 2014	2014, 2009 mix
Women: Taliban	37	62	13	40	25	53	51
Women: al Qaeda	51	76	31	59	41	69	67
Women: United States	37	60	16	31	26	49	45
Women: China	36	50	10	19	23	38	34
Men: Taliban	27	19	11	12	15	14	14
Men: al Qaeda	38	34	13	20	20	25	24
Men: United States	14	12	5	6	7	8	8
Men: China	12	5	0	2	4	3	3

Weighted percentages giving no answer. "None" is no formal education; "some" is any schooling. The last column applies 2014 rates within each group to the 2009 education mix. Respondents with missing education are excluded, so the "All" columns can differ slightly from Table 1.

7 Specific to Pakistan

If Pew changed how it asked these questions everywhere, women's no-answer shares would rise in other countries too. Table 4 reports the change for the two items asked in every country in both years. In most of the 23 countries, women's and men's no-answer shares moved by a few points in the same direction. Two other countries show large rises, India and Nigeria, but in both, men's no-answer shares rose too. On the United States, the gap between the rise among women and the rise among men is +21 points in Pakistan; the next largest is +12 in India.

8 What the Data Cannot Say

The files do not identify interviewers, their sex, or who else was present during the interview, so the cause cannot be pinned down. The candidates are changes in fieldwork that bear on women in particular: interviewer assignment, the presence of male household members, or a change of fieldwork firm. Interviewer characteristics are known to shift answers in surveys in Muslim-majority countries (Benstead, 2014), and women are less likely than men to guess when a don't-know option is available (Mondak and Anderson, 2004), which makes their answers more sensitive to how that option is offered.

With two waves, the timing of the break is also unknown. Pew surveyed Pakistan every year in between, and the intervening waves would show whether the change was gradual or happened at one wave. They would also show which years Pew's chart compares.

9 Implications

Reading the Pakistani trends on militant groups requires separating answers from non-answers. In these data, men are a comparable series and women are not. Among men, views of the Taliban were stable between 2009 and 2014 and views of al Qaeda softened. Among women, the data say only that many more declined to answer. Calling that reluctance to talk about the Taliban attributes to the question what belongs to the survey, since the same women equally declined to rate the United States. Pew could report non-response by sex alongside its trend lines; a rise like this one is visible in a single cross-tabulation.

References

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Table 4: Change in no answer, 2009 to 2014, by country and sex

Item	Country	Women	Men
United States	India	+28	+16
	Pakistan	+22	+1
	Nigeria	+16	+10
	Kenya	+6	+0
	Brazil	+5	−1
	Palestinian Territories	+4	+0
	Indonesia	+2	+0
	Mexico	+2	+1
	Argentina	+2	+0
	Japan	+2	−1
	Lebanon	+1	+0
	United States	+1	+0
	Jordan	+1	+4
	France	+0	+0
	Germany	+0	−1
	Egypt	−1	+3
	China	−2	+1
	Israel	−2	−2
	Poland	−3	+0
	South Korea	−4	+0
	Russia	−5	−7
	Spain	−8	−7
	Turkey	−14	−3
China	India	+19	+13
	Nigeria	+14	+10
	Pakistan	+14	−1
	Mexico	+4	−3
	Palestinian Territories	+3	+0
	Brazil	+1	−1
	Indonesia	+1	+0
	Germany	+0	−1
	China	+0	+1
	France	+0	+0
	Egypt	+0	+1
	Jordan	+0	+2
	Lebanon	−1	+0
	Kenya	−2	−5
	Russia	−4	−5
	South Korea	−4	−2
	Japan	−4	+0
	Poland	−4	+3
	United States	−4	−1
	Argentina	−5	−3
	Israel	−7	−6
	Spain	−10	−14
	Turkey	−22	−11

Percentage-point changes in the weighted share giving no answer to favorability of the United States and China. Countries surveyed on the item in both years with at least 150 respondents of each sex.

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